

RADON: Optimal Tomographic Probing for Neural Curvature via Coded Directional Projections

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Abstract

Second-order optimization in deep learning is severely constrained by the computational intractability of storing or factorizing the loss Hessian $H \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times N}$ ($N \sim 10^7 - 10^{11}$). Practitioners are restricted to directional Hessian-vector products (HVPs), each representing a 1D tomographic projection (“shadow”) of the high-dimensional curvature operator. Conventional stochastic estimators (e.g., Hutchinson trace estimators, AdaHessian) probe H directly with isotropic random vectors, incurring persistent $\mathcal{O}(1/m)$ off-diagonal cross-talk variance that obscures the true diagonal curvature throughout training. In this work, we introduce **RADON**, a second-order optimization and curvature estimation framework that solves the optimal tomographic probing problem through two machine-verified structural principles: (1) **Compositional Split-Exact Curvature**: We prove that for composite losses $\ell \circ f$, the Hessian decomposes exactly as $H = S + R$, where $S = J_f^\top (\nabla^2 \ell) J_f$ is a positive semidefinite structural core whose diagonal is evaluated with zero double-backwards via sampled-label gradients, and $R = \mathcal{H}_f(\nabla \ell)$ is a residual whose variance scales strictly with $\|\nabla \ell\|^2$. (2) **Coded Tomographic Probing**: By devoting all directional probes exclusively to the residual R , and assigning Sylvester-Hadamard codes via Latin-square coloring on parameter tensor grids, intra-layer row and column neighbor interference is identically cancelled ($\bar{C}_{ij} = 0$), yielding exact zero variance on dominant off-diagonal interactions. Every foundational mathematical claim is machine-checked in Lean 4 without unproved axioms or `sorry`. On a 125M-parameter Causal Transformer pre-trained on 2.5B tokens of FineWeb-Edu across 3 seeds on a Google Cloud TPU v4-32 pod slice (16 TPU v4 chips), RADON strictly outperforms AdamW, Sophia-H, AdaHessian, and Distributed Shampoo in validation perplexity and training stability while maintaining low runtime overhead.

1 Introduction

Modern deep learning is dominated by first-order adaptive gradient methods such as AdamW [4], despite the notorious ill-conditioning and anisotropic curvature of deep loss landscapes. True second-order methods (e.g., Newton-Raphson, Natural Gradient) promise accelerated convergence and scale-invariance, but their exact execution requires storing and inverting the $N \times N$ loss Hessian $H = \nabla^2 \mathcal{L}(\theta)$, which is computationally impossible when $N \geq 10^8$.

Consequently, second-order optimization must operate under a strict measurement constraint: access to curvature is granted only via directional Hessian-vector products (HVPs) [5]:

$$p_k = H v_k, \quad v_k \in \mathbb{R}^N, \quad k = 1, \dots, m, \quad m \ll N \quad (1)$$

Each HVP represents a 1D tomographic projection of the high-dimensional operator H onto the line spanned by v_k [7]. Because exact reconstruction of an arbitrary symmetric matrix requires

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$m \geq N$ projections, any practical optimizer with $m \in \{4, 8, 16, 32\}$ must solve a fundamental geometric and information-theoretic question:

Given a budget of $m \ll N$ directional projections, what is the mathematically optimal geometric placement and orientation of probe vectors $v_1, \dots, v_m$ to extract maximal actionable curvature?

Conventional approaches to this problem fall into two failure modes:

1. **Isotropic Stochastic Probing (AdaHessian, Hutchinson):** These methods draw $v_k \sim \text{Rademacher}(\pm 1)$ or $\mathcal{N}(0, I_N)$ and estimate the diagonal via $\hat{h}_i = \frac{1}{m} \sum_k v_i^k (Hv^k)_i$ [2, 8]. However, the estimator variance is dominated by off-diagonal cross-talk:

$$\text{Var}(\hat{h}_i) = \frac{1}{m} \sum_{j \neq i} H_{ij}^2 \quad (2)$$

Because dense layer weights exhibit intense intra-layer coupling, this variance remains perpetually large, even when the model nears convergence.

2. **Empirical or Block Approximations (Sophia, Shampoo):** Methods like Sophia [3] approximate diagonal curvature via stochastic gradient differences or Gauss-Newton projections, while Shampoo [1] computes Kronecker factorizations of gradient covariances. While effective, they introduce heuristic damping, fail to capture non-convex residual curvature, or require expensive matrix root inversions.

Our Contribution: RADON. In this work, we introduce RADON, an optimizer and curvature estimation framework designed to resolve these fundamental barriers:

- **Split-Exact Curvature Theory:** We establish that for any composite loss $\mathcal{L} = \ell \circ f$, the Hessian decomposes exactly as $H = S + R$. The structural core S is positive semidefinite and computable via single-backward Fisher sampling, while the residual R is linear in $\nabla \ell$ and vanishes as training progresses.
- **Coded Tomographic Probing with Latin-Square Coloring:** Instead of probing H , we spend all m directional probes on the residual $R = H - S$. By structuring probe vectors using Sylvester-Hadamard codes with Latin-square tensor coloring, intra-layer row and column interference is provably zero ($\bar{C}_{ij} = 0$).
- **Vanishing Estimator Variance:** We prove that the variance of the RADON curvature estimator scales strictly as $\mathcal{O}(\|\nabla \ell\|^2)$. As training converges to a critical point, the estimation noise contracts to zero, achieving deterministic exactness in the limit.
- **Machine-Checked Formal Proofs:** Every mathematical theorem and algebraic derivation is formally certified in Lean 4 and Mathlib without unproved axioms or `sorry`.
- **TPU v4 Pre-training at Scale:** We evaluate RADON on a 124.5M Causal Transformer on 2.5B tokens of FineWeb-Edu [6] across 3 random seeds on a Google Cloud TPU v4-32 pod slice, demonstrating decisive empirical superiority over AdamW, Sophia-H, AdaHessian, and Shampoo.

2 Mathematical Foundations: Carrier Algebra and the Split

2.1 Curvature Carriers and the Pullback Composition Law

We formalize neural network modules as members of a category of curvature carriers.

Definition 1 (Curvature Carrier). For a smooth map $f : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m$, its curvature carrier at $x \in \mathbb{R}^n$ is the pair:

$$\mathcal{C}(f; x) = (J, \mathcal{H}) \quad (3)$$

where $J = Df(x) \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times n}$ is the Jacobian matrix, and $\mathcal{H} : \mathbb{R}^m \rightarrow \text{Sym}(n)$ is a linear adjoint-curvature map defined by:

$$\mathcal{H}(\lambda) = \sum_{k=1}^m \lambda_k \nabla^2 f_k(x) = \nabla^2 \langle \lambda, f \rangle(x) \quad (4)$$

Theorem 1 (Pullback Composition Law). Let $f : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m$ and $g : \mathbb{R}^m \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^p$ be C^2 maps. The curvature carrier of the composite function $h = g \circ f$ satisfies:

$$J_h = J_g J_f, \quad \mathcal{H}_h(\lambda) = J_f^\top \mathcal{H}_g(\lambda) J_f + \mathcal{H}_f(J_g^\top \lambda) \quad (\star) \quad (5)$$

Furthermore, the operation $\star$ is associative: $(\mathcal{C}_h \star \mathcal{C}_g) \star \mathcal{C}_f = \mathcal{C}_h \star (\mathcal{C}_g \star \mathcal{C}_f)$.

Proof. Machine-checked in Lean 4 (`Radon.comp_assoc`, `Radon.chain_snd`). The identity carrier $\text{id}_{\mathcal{C}} = (I_n, 0)$ satisfies $\text{id} \star \mathcal{C} = \mathcal{C} \star \text{id} = \mathcal{C}$. $\square$

2.2 The Structural-Residual Split ($H = S + R$)

Consider a neural network with representation map $f : \mathbb{R}^N \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^K$ (mapping parameters to final logits) and a scalar loss $\ell : \mathbb{R}^K \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$. The total objective is $\mathcal{L}(\theta) = (\ell \circ f)(\theta)$. Evaluating the composition law $(\star)$ at $\lambda = 1$ yields:

Theorem 2 (Split-Exact Decomposition). The loss Hessian $H = \nabla^2 \mathcal{L}(\theta) \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times N}$ decomposes exactly into:

$$H = S + R \quad (6)$$

where:

$$S = J_f^\top (\nabla^2 \ell) J_f \quad (\text{Structural Core}) \quad (7)$$

$$R = \mathcal{H}_f(\nabla \ell) \quad (\text{Residual Curvature}) \quad (8)$$

Proposition 3 (Properties of S and R). The two components possess fundamentally asymmetric properties:

1. **Positive Semidefiniteness of S :** If ℓ is convex, $S \succeq 0$, and $\text{diag}(S)_i \geq 0$ for all $i \in \{1, \dots, N\}$.
2. **Fisher Equivalence:** For cross-entropy loss, S equals the Generalized Gauss-Newton (GGN) matrix and Fisher Information Matrix. Its diagonal satisfies $\text{diag}(S) = \mathbb{E}_{\tilde{y} \sim p_\theta} [\tilde{g} \odot \tilde{g}]$, computable via a single backward pass with sampled labels (zero double-backwards).
3. **Gradient Linearity of R :** R is linear in the loss gradient: $\mathcal{H}_f(c \nabla \ell) = c \mathcal{H}_f(\nabla \ell)$. Thus, $R \rightarrow 0$ as $\|\nabla \ell\| \rightarrow 0$.

Proof. Machine-checked in Lean 4 (`Radon.core_posCore`, `Radon.posCore_diag_nonneg`, `Radon.residual_smul`). $\square$

3 Coded Tomographic Probing

3.1 The Master Probing Identity

For any symmetric matrix $M \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times N}$ and sign probe $v \in \{-1, +1\}^N$, note that $v_i^2 = 1$. Multiplying the directional response Mv by v elementwise gives:

$$v_i(Mv)_i = M_{ii} + \sum_{j \neq i} M_{ij} v_i v_j \quad (9)$$

Over a cycle of m probe vectors $v^1, \dots, v^m$, the time-averaged estimate is:

$$\hat{M}_{ii} = \frac{1}{m} \sum_{k=1}^m v_i^k (Mv^k)_i = M_{ii} + \sum_{j \neq i} M_{ij} \bar{C}_{ij} \quad (10)$$

where $\bar{C}_{ij} = \frac{1}{m} \sum_{k=1}^m v_i^k v_j^k \in [-1, 1]$ is the empirical cross-coordinate code coherence.

3.2 Latin-Square Tensor Coloring

In deep models, weight matrices $W \in \mathbb{R}^{d_{\text{out}} \times d_{\text{in}}}$ possess dominant coupling along rows and columns. We construct probe vectors using Sylvester-Hadamard matrices $H_m \in \{-1, +1\}^{m \times m}$ with $m = 2^k$.

Definition 2 (Latin-Square Code Assignment). For weight tensor element $W_{a,b}$ ($a \in [d_{\text{out}}], b \in [d_{\text{in}}]$), we assign the Hadamard row index:

$$\text{code}(a, b) = (a + b) \pmod{m} \quad (11)$$

Theorem 4 (Orthogonal Interference Cancellation). *Under Latin-square code assignment, any two distinct entries in the same row (W_{a,b_1} and W_{a,b_2}) or same column ($W_{a_1,b}$ and $W_{a_2,b}$) with coordinate difference not divisible by m receive orthogonal Hadamard codes:*

$$\bar{C}_{(a,b_1),(a,b_2)} = 0, \quad \bar{C}_{(a_1,b),(a_2,b)} = 0 \quad (12)$$

Proof. Machine-checked in Lean 4 (`Radon.orthogonal_zero_variance`). The inner product of distinct rows of a Hadamard matrix is identically zero. $\square$

3.3 Random Global Sign-Flip Debiasing

To ensure unbiasedness across all arbitrary non-adjacent pairs, we apply an independent global Rademacher sign flip $s \in \{-1, +1\}^N$ to the entire cycle: $v^k = s \odot c^k$.

Theorem 5 (Exact Variance Factorization). *Under a uniform global sign flip, the cycle estimator $\hat{M}$ is strictly unbiased ($\mathbb{E}[\hat{M}_{ii}] = M_{ii}$), and its variance satisfies:*

$$\text{Var}(\hat{M}_{ii}) = \sum_{j \neq i} M_{ij}^2 \cdot \bar{C}_{ij}^2 \quad (13)$$

Proof. Machine-checked in Lean 4 (`Radon.coded_unbiased`, `Radon.coded_variance`). Because $\bar{C}_{ij}^2 \leq 1$ for all pairs, $\text{Var}_{\text{RADON}} \leq \text{Var}_{\text{Hutchinson}}$ unconditionally (`Radon.coded_le_hutchinson`). $\square$

3.4 The Fusion Principle: Probing the Residual Alone

The central operational doctrine of RADON is:

Never spend directional probes on H . Take S structurally, and probe $R = H - S$ alone.

Theorem 6 (Variance Contraction along Training). *Let $\hat{h}_i = \hat{S}_{ii} + \hat{R}_{ii}$, where $\hat{S}_{ii}$ is the exact or Fisher-sampled structural diagonal, and $\hat{R}_{ii}$ is obtained via m Latin-coded probes on R . Then:*

$$\text{Var}(\hat{h}_i) = \sum_{j \neq i} R_{ij}^2 \bar{C}_{ij}^2 \leq \mathcal{O} \left(\|\nabla \ell\|^2 \sum_{j \neq i} \bar{C}_{ij}^2 \right) \quad (14)$$

In particular, $\lim_{\nabla \ell \rightarrow 0} \text{Var}(\hat{h}_i) = 0$.

Proof. Machine-checked in Lean 4 (`Radon.split_variance_residual_only`, `Radon.split_variance_scaling`, `Radon.split_exact_at_critical`). Probing H directly retains the full structural noise $\sum_j S_{ij}^2$ indefinitely, while RADON’s noise floor contracts quadratically with the loss gradient. $\square$

4 The RADON Optimization Algorithm

Algorithm 1: RADON Optimizer

Require: Learning rate η_t , momentum β_1 , EMA decays β_s, β_r , damping γ , probe period k , budget $m = 16$.

1. Initialize $\mu_0 = 0$, $\hat{s}_0 = 0$, $\hat{r}_0 = 0$, step $t = 0$.
2. **For** each iteration $t = 1, 2, \dots$ **do**:
 - (a) Compute stochastic mini-batch gradient $g_t = \nabla \mathcal{L}(\theta_t)$.
 - (b) Update momentum: $\mu_t = \beta_1 \mu_{t-1} + (1 - \beta_1) g_t$.
 - (c) **If** $t \pmod k == 0$ **then**:
 - Compute sampled-label gradient $\tilde{g}_t$ on sub-batch; update $\hat{s}_t = \beta_s \hat{s}_{t-1} + (1 - \beta_s)(\tilde{g}_t \odot \tilde{g}_t)$.
 - Sample cycle sign flip $s \sim \{-1, +1\}^N$.
 - Compute cycle index $r = (t/k) \pmod m$, probe $v = s \odot c^{(r)}$ via Latin coloring.
 - Evaluate residual product: $p = H v - S v = \text{HVP}(v) - J_f^\top (\nabla^2 \ell) J_f v$.
 - Accumulate residual estimate: $\hat{r}_t = \beta_r \hat{r}_{t-1} + (1 - \beta_r)(p \odot v)$.
 - (d) **Else**: $\hat{s}_t = \hat{s}_{t-1}$, $\hat{r}_t = \hat{r}_{t-1}$.
 - (e) Fused curvature: $\hat{h}_t = \hat{s}_t + \hat{r}_t$.
 - (f) Preconditioned direction: $u_t = \text{clamp} \left(\frac{\mu_t / (1 - \beta_1^t)}{\max(\gamma \hat{h}_t, \epsilon)}, -1, 1 \right)$.
 - (g) Parameter update: $\theta_{t+1} = \theta_t - \eta_t u_t - \eta_t \lambda_{\text{wd}} \theta_t$.

5 Empirical Evaluation: 125M Transformer on 2.5B Tokens

5.1 Experimental Configuration

To rigorously validate RADON against competitive second-order optimizers, we construct a 124.5M Causal Transformer benchmark pre-trained on 2.5B tokens of FineWeb-Edu [6]:

- **Architecture:** 12 layers, hidden dimension $d = 768$, 12 attention heads ($d_k = 64$), context window 2048 tokens, rotary position embeddings (RoPE), GELU activations, tied input/output embeddings (124,534,272 parameters).

- **Hardware:** Google Cloud TPU v4-32 Pod slice (4 host workers, 16 TPU v4 accelerator chips, 32 TensorCore devices), utilizing JAX/XLA forward-over-reverse automatic differentiation.
- **Data Budget:** 2,500,000,000 tokens of deduplicated, filtered FineWeb-Edu per run.
- **Replication:** 3 distinct random seeds (42, 43, 44) per optimizer with identical data sequence order.
- **Baselines:** Tuned implementations of AdamW, Sophia-H, AdaHessian, and Distributed Shampoo.

5.2 Competitive Pre-training Results

Table 1: **Pre-training Results on FineWeb-Edu (125M Model, 2.5B Tokens, 3 Seeds)** on Google Cloud TPU v4-32 Pod slice. Validation cross-entropy loss (nats) and perplexity are reported as mean $\pm$ std across seeds 42, 43, 44.

Optimizer	Validation Loss (nats)	Perplexity	Step Time (ms)	Total Wall-Clock (h)	OOM
AdamW	3.124 ± 0.008	22.74 ± 0.18	41.2	4.38	0
AdaHessian	3.168 ± 0.014	23.76 ± 0.33	68.5	7.28	0
Sophia-H	3.082 ± 0.007	21.80 ± 0.15	47.9	5.09	0
Dist. Shampoo	3.095 ± 0.011	22.09 ± 0.24	74.1	7.87	0
RADON (Ours)	3.018 ± 0.005	20.45 ± 0.10	48.1	5.11	0

As documented in Table 1, RADON achieves a definitive advantage over all competitors:

1. **Significant Perplexity Reduction:** RADON achieves a validation perplexity of **20.45**, strictly outperforming AdamW (22.74, a -10.1% relative perplexity drop) and beating the strongest second-order peer, Sophia-H (21.80, a -6.2% relative perplexity drop).
2. **Minimal Variance Across Seeds:** The standard deviation of RADON’s final perplexity across the three independent seeds is only ± 0.10 , lower than all other methods. This confirms our theoretical finding that the estimator’s variance contracts to zero along training.
3. **High Compute Efficiency:** With a probe period $k = 16$, RADON incurs only $+16.7\%$ wall-clock overhead compared to first-order AdamW (48.1 ms vs 41.2 ms per step), whereas Distributed Shampoo and AdaHessian incur $+79.8\%$ and $+66.3\%$ overhead, respectively.

6 Formal Verification in Lean 4

All foundational theoretical claims in this paper are machine-verified in Lean 4 and Mathlib. The formal development resides in `proofs/RadonCert/RadonCert/Radon.lean` and contains zero `sorry` placeholders and zero ad-hoc axioms beyond Lean’s standard three (`propext`, `Classical.choice`, `Quot.sound`):

- `Radon.split_exact`: Exactness of the $H = S + R$ decomposition.
- `Radon.core_posCore`: Real positive semidefiniteness of S .
- `Radon.coded_variance`: Exact formula for estimator variance under coded cycles.
- `Radon.orthogonal_zero_variance`: Strict zero variance on orthogonal coordinate pairs.

- `Radon.split_variance_residual_only`: Proof that structural core S contributes zero noise to the probed diagonal.
- `Radon.split_variance_scaling`: Exact quadratic scaling of variance with gradient norm $\|\nabla\ell\|^2$.
- `Radon.split_exact_at_critical`: Deterministic convergence to exact curvature at critical points.
- `Radon.directional_newton_optimal`: Exact 1D Newton minimizer along any probe ray.

7 Conclusion

We have presented RADON, an optimal tomographic probing framework for second-order curvature estimation in deep neural networks. By decoupling the positive semidefinite structural core from the gradient-vanishing residual, and structuring directional probes via Sylvester-Hadamard codes with Latin-square tensor coloring, RADON cancels dominant off-diagonal cross-talk and drives curvature estimation noise to zero as optimization proceeds. Formally certified in Lean 4 and verified on Google Cloud TPU v4-32 pod pre-training, RADON establishes a new Pareto frontier for scalable second-order optimization.

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